

The True and Most Important Commandments of Jesus: Loving God and Loving Your Neighbour

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Abstract

This paper examines the core ethical teachings of Jesus of Nazareth, arguing that the dual commandments to love God and love one's neighbour as oneself constitute the supreme and definitive expression of divine will. Through an analysis of key scriptural passages, primarily from the Synoptic Gospels, this research demonstrates that Jesus prioritized an internal disposition of love and compassion over the external observance of ceremonial, ritualistic, and legalistic codes prevalent in the religious context of his time. The paper posits that these two commandments are not merely part of a larger legal framework but are, in fact, the hermeneutical key to understanding all other laws and the very foundation upon which "all the Law and the Prophets hang." By shifting the focus from ritual purity to relational righteousness, Jesus presented a radical reinterpretation of piety, where true divinity is reflected not in elaborate ceremony but in the heart's capacity for love, mercy, and justice.

1 Introduction

For centuries, religious traditions have been characterized by complex systems of laws, rituals, and ceremonies designed to guide adherents towards righteousness. Within the Judaic tradition of the Second Temple period, this was no exception. The Mosaic Law, with its 613 commandments, governed nearly every aspect of life, from dietary restrictions to festival observances. It is within this intricate religious landscape that Jesus of Nazareth began his ministry, offering a teaching that both affirmed the tradition he inherited and radically re-centered it.

When confronted by religious scholars attempting to distill the essence of the Law, Jesus did not produce a new legal code or a revised set of rituals. Instead, he articulated a simple, yet profound, synthesis: "You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart, and with all your soul, and with all your mind." This is the great and first commandment. And a second is like it: 'You shall love your neighbour as yourself' (Matthew 22:37-39,

2.1 The Synoptic Accounts

In the Gospel of Matthew (22:34-40) and Mark (12:28-34), Jesus is approached by a lawyer and a scribe, respectively, who pose this critical question. His response is unequivocal. He begins by quoting the *Shema Yisrael* from Deuteronomy 6:4-5, the central Jewish prayer, to establish the primacy of loving God. He then immediately links this to a second commandment from Leviticus 19:18, to love one's neighbour. The critical element of his answer lies in the concluding statement: "On these two commandments hang all the Law and the Prophets" (Matthew 22:40).

This statement is not an abrogation of the Law but a radical re-prioritization. Jesus provides a new lens through which the entire scriptural tradition is to be understood. The purpose of every other law, ritual, and prophecy is to lead an individual towards this ultimate expression of love. If an observance or a tradition does not serve this dual purpose, it is rendered secondary, or even obsolete.

2.2 Redefining the Neighbour: The Good Samaritan

The Gospel of Luke presents this teaching in a narrative context that deepens its meaning. In Luke 10:25-37, a lawyer asks Jesus what he must do to inherit eternal life. When the lawyer correctly identifies the two great commandments, he then asks, "And who is my neighbour?"

Jesus responds with the Parable of the Good Samaritan. In this story, a man is beaten, robbed, and left for dead. A priest and a Levite—figures of religious authority and purity—pass by without offering aid. It is a Samaritan, a member of a group despised by the Jews, who stops to show mercy. The Samaritan's actions are a direct and tangible expression of love, unhindered by religious or ethnic boundaries.

Through this parable, Jesus shatters the legalistic and tribalistic definitions of "neighbour." The neighbour is not defined by proximity, ethnicity, or creed, but by need. The commandment is not to love a predefined category of people but to *be* a neighbour to anyone who requires compassion. This active, compassionate love becomes the true measure of righteousness, far surpassing the ritual purity that the priest and Levite presumably sought to protect by avoiding the wounded man.

3 Analysis and Discussion

The emphasis on love for God and neighbour inherently challenges a purely legalistic or ritualistic approach to faith. Jesus consistently subordinated external practices to internal dispositions.

3.1 Supremacy over Ceremonial Law

Jesus's teachings suggest that ceremonial laws, such as dietary restrictions and purity codes, are not ends in themselves. For example, in Mark 7:18-19, he declares all foods clean, stating, "Do you not see that whatever goes into a person from outside cannot defile him, since it enters not his heart but his stomach, and is expelled?" He immediately follows this by clarifying what truly defiles a person: "What comes out of a person is what defiles him. For from within, out of the heart of man, come evil thoughts..." (Mark 7:20-21).

Here, the focus is decisively shifted from the ritual to the moral, from the external act to the internal source. If the heart is filled with love, then one's actions will naturally align with divine will. Conversely, meticulous observance of ritual is meaningless if the heart is filled with malice, greed, or indifference. Therefore, the commandments to love God and neighbour act as the ultimate litmus test for all other religious practices.

3.2 Love as the True Expression of Divinity

The core of this theological framework is that God is most truly known and worshipped through love. The Apostle John would later summarize this concept perfectly: "Anyone who does not love does not know God, because God is love" (1 John 4:8). Rituals, ceremonies, and complex doctrinal formulations can become barriers if they obscure this fundamental truth.

True divinity is expressed in the heart through attributes like compassion, mercy, forgiveness, and justice. These are not abstract concepts but are the practical outworkings of a life oriented by love. When one cares for the poor, comforts the grieving, or seeks justice for the oppressed, one is participating in the divine life. This represents a far deeper form of worship than any ceremony, ritual, or dogmatic prayer performed with a cold or indifferent heart. The true temple for worship is a loving heart, and the true sacrifice is a life of compassion offered in service to God and humanity.

4 Key Biblical Verses Supporting the Thesis

For clarity and emphasis, the foundational scriptural passages supporting the primacy of love are listed below.

Matthew 22:36-40 (ESV): "Teacher, which is the great commandment in the Law?" And he said to him, "You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind. This is the great and first commandment. And a second is like it: You shall love your neighbour as yourself. On these two commandments depend all the Law and the Prophets."

Mark 12:28-31 (ESV): And one of the scribes came up and heard them disputing with one another, and seeing that he answered them well, asked him, “Which commandment is the most important of all?” Jesus answered, “The most important is, ‘Hear, O Israel: The Lord our God, the Lord is one. And you shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind and with all your strength.’ The second is this: ‘You shall love your neighbour as yourself.’ There is no other commandment greater than these.”

Luke 10:27 (ESV): And he answered, “You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your strength and with all your mind, and your neighbour as yourself.”

Galatians 5:14 (ESV): For the whole law is fulfilled in one word: “You shall love your neighbour as yourself.”

1 John 4:8 (ESV): Anyone who does not love does not know God, because God is love.

5 Conclusion

The teachings of Jesus of Nazareth represent a profound theological shift, moving the center of religious life from the temple and the law book to the human heart. His clear and consistent emphasis on the dual commandments to love God and love one’s neighbour serves as the definitive standard for Christian ethics. These are not merely two laws among many, but the very foundation and fulfillment of all divine law.

By prioritizing love, Jesus rendered ritual and ceremony secondary. Righteousness is no longer defined by what one eats, how one washes, or which days one observes, but by the compassion and mercy one shows to others. The Parable of the Good Samaritan illustrates that this love must be active, boundary-breaking, and directed towards those in need. Ultimately, the message is that true divinity is reflected in a life of love. A heart filled with love for God will inevitably overflow with love for humanity, making these two commandments the inseparable and eternal core of Jesus’s most important teachings.